

and the rebels are the weakest. The Congress has already agreed to leave about 10 seats each for the rebels and NCP. As a rebel leader confided: "We are playing our cards in such a manner that Modi will be hemmed in from all sides."

The Congress's confidence level got a boost following a successful women's rally addressed by party President Sonia Gandhi in Anand, the den of Gujarat Congress chief Bharati Solanki, who had won the Lok Sabha seat against all odds in the previous elections. Indicating the Congress's strategy of joining hands with the BJP rebels, Sonia spoke their language: "Let's uproot this dispensation based on fear, hatred and corruption. This administration is based on an attitude that smacks of revenge and lack of sensitivity."

The Congress is playing down the Gujarat riots expose and Modi's alleged role in it, except on the issue of compensation for the riot victims, but typically, the party does not speak in one voice. While Sonia stuck to the script, Union Minister for Science and Technology Kapil Sibal took a different line last week, much to the chagrin of state Congress leaders. He declared that if the Congress was voted to power in the state, Modi should be prepared to face prosecution as an accused in the riots case. The statement, which generated a lot of heat, might affect the Congress adversely by shoring up Modi's Hindu votebank.

A desperate situation calls for desperate measures. For once, the Congress is not averse to diluting its secular slogan. Three days after the expose, 11 Hindus were convicted in the Eral village of Panchmahal district,



GANGING UP: (Top to bottom) Sonia Gandhi at Anand, Bharati, Keshubhai Patel with other rebel leaders

where 11 Muslims were killed in 2002. Soon after the judgement, Rajendra Patel, a senior Congress leader from the Godhra region, issued a statement sympathising with the killers. Siding with the convicts, he said they were innocent and had fallen prey to the evil designs of the Sangh Parivar. For the Congress, the overall strategy of ignoring the 2002 episode and attacking Modi on his claims of good governance is the best bet.

The Congress has put together an attractive visual series titled 'Gujarat jago, hisab maango (awake, Gujarat, and ask for an explanation)'. One of the

ads in the campaign highlights the alleged failures of the Modi Government, and shows a housewife saying dejectedly: "This is not the Gujarat for which we voted BJP to power last time."

The party, up against a formidable face like Modi, has chosen not to project a chief ministerial candidate for fear of triggering dissension in the party. Solanki, who has revived a crestfallen Congress in less than two years, or Shankarsinh Vaghela, former chief minister and Modi's sworn political foe, could have been projected for the top post.

On his part, the chief minister's silence is deafening. His strategy is to ignore the barbs and maintain a direct rapport with the people by convincing them that his Government has performed well. Instead of causing him damage, the Tehelka expose has only bolstered his Hindutva image. His problems stem from the enemy within. Apart from countering the rebels, Modi will have to replace a large number of MLAs who are facing anti-incumbency in their constituencies. Feedback from the ground level indicates that a large chunk of the electorate is willing to back him but not the sitting MLAs. Undertaking a drastic overhaul by axing a large number of sitting MLAs could force more defections to the rebel camp, but leaving them in place would mean losing seats. With the rebels and Bharati putting up formidable opposition, this election is Modi's biggest challenge yet. He will have to rely on a strong dose of Hindutva along with his developmental tune. Modi may still be in the driver's seat electorally, but the hazard lights are blinking. ■